Perfect Circle

By Carly Johnstone

(Pg 220-228) I was sixteen [and] my life had been a lesson in negatives. I had been a lesson in what ***not*** to do. My mantra had been "How not to be my mother." My mother was a prostitute, and I had grown up with her, and many other prostitutes, and the men that handled them. When she died in the 1980s, like so many from AIDS, I went into foster care. [It was] a year and a half before my mother's parents, my grandparents, took me in under duress . . . people who don't want children probably shouldn't have them. They lasted about five years with me before they threw in the towel, retired to Florida, and put me in a Southern Baptist children's home.

[After] about a year and a half there I thought, *I could do better than this. I could raise myself.* I mean, the bar was pretty low. I studied a lot, took a lot of tests, and graduated high school two and a half years early. I got on a Greyhound and went back to New Jersey, because that's where I grew up and that's where I felt safe. I started college at a local community college. I got my first full-time job with full health benefits, and I got my first place. And by the end of my sixteenth year, a wrench was thrown in the works. I was pregnant.

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INTRODUCTION

Carly Johnstone was a survivor – a strong young woman who proves the quote from Mary Anne Radmacher: "Courage doesn't always roar. Sometimes courage is the little voice at the end of the day that says I'll try again tomorrow." This is her story -- A story of a family bound together, not by blood, but by choice.

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I knew a few things right off the bat: I wasn't going to abort. It wasn't because of some misbegotten belief in God or because I'm pro-life, because I'm not. I desperately wanted this baby; I always wanted a family -- something that was mine and pure and good and whole.

I wanted it, but I couldn't keep the promises I had made to myself about having a family. That whole mantra about not being my mom; I couldn't give this kid a home. I couldn't give a life without fear or want. And so I had to find another solution. I looked at traditional adoption, but I

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couldn't have a kid grow up the way I did, with so many questions about who I was and where I came from. And I looked at fostering, but again, you know, I had traveled that road. It hadn't really gone so well.

Finally, someone explained open adoption. It means that the adoptive parents want an ongoing relationship with the mother; and the mother -- she gets to choose the parents. And I thought, *I can do this. I can do this.*

So, I attacked this like I attack everything else in my life, like a research paper. I made a lot of calls and took a lot of notes, and I finally found an agency that could meet my criteria.

I had three. My first was that it had to be a same-sex couple, because, at this time, it was a little harder for them to adopt. Additionally, I realized that if I ever found anyone to settle down with, it would be another woman. I never wanted *that* to be an issue.

Number two: they had to not have any extreme religious affiliation. I had had religion shoved down my throat, and I thought faith should be a choice.

Number three: they had to want an interracial child as their first choice. The father of this baby was black,

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and I was half very white and half something very brown. I didn't want it to be something they settled upon because they couldn't find a perfect blond-haired, blue-eyed baby, or because they were trying to better their karma.

Even with those narrow parameters, I had over two hundred couples that were viable choices, and each of them had a brochure. Each brochure was full of pictures of their family and friends and their homes, and information about how well educated they were, how much support they had, and how financially stable they were.

Eventually I found a couple that I really liked. Their names were Gwen and Gretchen. They lived in Portland, Maine, which was far enough for me. I didn't want them to be too close, because I knew I might be a stalker mom, and I didn't want to find myself on a playground. So they were close enough that I could get there if I needed to, but also far enough away that I couldn't run there in ten minutes.

They came down from Maine to meet me. Gretchen is tall and strong and unflappable, and Gweny is tiny and

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sweet and nurturing. And I liked them, and they liked me, which was really important because they had to deal with me for a really long time, and a lot of people had not really hung in there.

I knew they were the right ones. And we waited the wait of expectant parents. Eventually we found ourselves in this delivery room, and after twenty-three hours of labor, I gave birth to an eight-pound, six-ounce baby boy. And he was perfect. And he was whole. And he was so beautiful.

I had forty-eight hours with him, and I sang him every song I knew. *(insert brief song here)* I tried to say hello to him, and I tried to say good-bye. And at the end of that forty-eight hours, I brought him downstairs, and helped them strap him into a car seat, and I watched these strangers drive away with my baby.

I hoped I had made the right choice. I hoped they were the right people. I hoped he would forgive me.

Up until this point I had never cried, but when I went home, I finally did. I shattered. I broke into a million pieces. I looked at my body, this seventeen-year-old body that should be healthy and strong and young, and it was broken

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too. I had stretch marks that looked like purple claws. My stomach that had so recently been filled with life was flaccid and dead. My breasts were heavy, hard, swollen and leaking, trying to feed a child that wasn't there, a baby that was gone.

And I didn't know what to do. I had had such a good start, but I stopped living the mantra of how not to be my mother. I did my best to prove I was just as bad as her. I was someone that could give away a baby. I was the person that could throw away a child. And after never drinking and never smoking and never doing anything bad, that's all I did for the next three or four years. I tried to destroy myself as quickly as possible.

After four years, I made my way to Maine. I finally got up the courage to visit this family that had my child. I went to their home, and it was beautiful. The kitchen was the kind of place where everyone goes to tell their story and friends meet. And all I saw was everything I wasn't; all I saw was a bar I would never meet. And I watched these people raise a child that I was incapable of holding or touching or saying "I love you" to, because I didn't know how to do that. I didn't know how to do it for myself; I didn't know

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how to do it for him. I just hadn't been given those tools in my life.

I did realize on that trip that I had to be someone who -- when this kid was old enough to ask questions -- was worthy of being asked.

I went home, and I stopped doing all of those horrible things to myself. I made better friends and started building my own family of supporters. Eventually I got better, and every year in August I would visit them, and every year it was a little easier to talk, and it was a little easier to share, and it wasn't so terrible when people stared at me and said, "You look just like him."

When he was turning nine, I was invited to a seminar about an hour north of Portland. We were asked to bring something we needed to get rid of, and I had a lot. But the one thing that I had to really get rid of was this idea that I was Henry's mother (that's his name, Henry), because I wasn't.

There's a big difference between the person that gives birth to you and the people that raise you. I knew that from my own life; it just took me a long time to learn that lesson for myself.

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After [the seminar I] went to Portland. This [seminar] hadn't changed me as a human being, it had just changed my perception. I realized these people -- these wonderful people who did such an amazing job raising this brilliant kid -- had given me the only blueprint I had. They had given me the foundation for what a family should be, what love was and loyalty, and what a mother could be. What two moms could be. I left there, and it was the first time I did not cry all the way to Boston and scream until New Jersey.

The year he was turning ten, I found I was pregnant again, but this time it was different because I had spent years trying to build a real family. The people in my life were so excited because this baby was the first in our family of friends. I was still poor, and I hadn't completed my education, but I wasn't alone. I had wonderful friends; and they called, and they wrote, and they filled a storage space with baby things.

When my daughter was born, everything was so different.

Henry carries a picture of Asha in his wallet. (I named her Asha; it means "hope".) My son will be fourteen this year, and in April, when Asha turned four, he came with his

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mother, Gretchen, to our house and shared our home and stayed with our family and all the people that chose to be there, and I watched him hold her and play with her. I saw them as part of my family for the first time, really understanding that they were part of me too. I watched this beautiful, brilliant, strong boy carry his beautiful, brilliant little sister and realized that he had become a part of the net that would hold her up.

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